You Are Not Prepared For the Internet Going Down: Checklist

Why each item matters, and the rest of the post: nomagicpill.site/thoughts/draftinternetdown.html. Updated 31 October 2026.
Amounts are per person or per household, for a 30-day plan. For your household's totals, enter it on the page and print your own list.

Practices

First hour

- [ ] **Confirm it's really down**: restart your phone and router, then ask a neighbor or walk to a store or gas station and see whether their card readers work.
- [ ] **Turn on the radio**: tune to your area's main AM news station or the NOAA weather channel, and check back on the hour.
- [ ] **Charge everything**: phones, power banks, laptops, headlamps, and the power station, while the power is still on.
- [ ] **Fill the bathtub and any empty containers**: water systems run on electric pumps and networked controls, so pressure can drop without warning.
- [ ] **Text, don't call**: send short texts to family instead of calling, if your phone has any signal.

First day

- [ ] **Top up what's still for sale**: if a store or gas station is open and taking cash, fill the gas tank and pick up prescriptions and anything you're short on.
- [ ] **Check on neighbors**: especially older or disabled ones, and anyone who lives alone.
- [ ] **Save your phone battery**: turn on low power mode, lower the brightness, and switch to airplane mode when you don't need it.
- [ ] **Eat from the fridge first**: if the power is out too, eat what's in the fridge, then the freezer, then the pantry, and keep the doors shut.
- [ ] **Unplug electronics** if the power goes out: everything but one lamp, which tells you when it's back.

Until it's back

- [ ] **Assume it'll last**: plan for at least two weeks until the radio says otherwise.
- [ ] **Drive only when you have to**: treat dead traffic lights as four-way stops, which is the law in most states.
- [ ] **Keep washing your hands**: before eating and after using the toilet bucket.
- [ ] **Keep a paper log**: write down radio updates, which stores and stations are open, and when.

Tier 1

1. Cash

- [ ] **Amount**: $500-2,000 per household, or a few weeks of normal spending.
- [ ] **Small bills**: mostly 1s, 5s, 10s, and 20s.

2. Water, 2 weeks

- [ ] **Stored water** `14 gal per person`: 1 gallon per person per day for up to two weeks, in 7-gallon jugs like the Reliance Aqua-Tainer or in cases of bottled water.
- [ ] **Filter** `1 per household`: a squeeze filter like the Sawyer Squeeze (~$40) or a gravity filter like the Platypus GravityWorks.
- [ ] **Unscented bleach** `1 bottle per household`: regular household bleach (5-9% sodium hypochlorite, not scented or "splash-less") as a backup for treating water: 8 drops per gallon of clear water, 16 if it's cloudy, then wait 30 minutes (CDC).
- [ ] **Bathtub**: fill it the moment you hear about an outage, since water pressure can fail if the utility's pumps or controls go down.

3. Food, 2 weeks of things you already eat

- [ ] **Canned goods** `14 cans per person`: soup, chili, beans, tuna, chicken, vegetables, and fruit.
- [ ] **Peanut butter** `1 jar per person`: about 2,700 calories per 16 oz jar, with protein and fat, no cooking, and months of shelf life.
- [ ] **Oats** `1 canister per person`: rolled or quick oats.
- [ ] **Pasta** `3 lb per person`: cheap calories, but it takes a lot of water and fuel to cook.
- [ ] **Rice** `3 lb per person`: white rice keeps for years; brown rice goes rancid in months.
- [ ] **Shelf-stable milk** `4 quarts per person`: boxed UHT milk (e.g. Horizon or Parmalat) or powdered milk, which keeps for months unopened without a fridge.
- [ ] **Ready-to-eat snacks** `3 boxes per person`: granola or protein bars, crackers, trail mix, and jerky.
- [ ] **Coffee or tea**, if you drink it: instant coffee works without a coffee maker, and caffeine withdrawal headaches are miserable.
- [ ] **Manual can opener** `1 per household`: a hand-crank one like the OXO Good Grips (~$15).

4. Medicine

- [ ] **Spare glasses or contacts**: an old pair of glasses or an extra box of contacts.

5. Light, power, and alerts

- [ ] **Headlamps** `1 per person`: e.g. a Petzl Tikka or Black Diamond Spot (~$30-50).
- [ ] **AA/AAA batteries** `1 pack of 24 per person`: enough to replace everything twice.
- [ ] **Power banks** `1 per person (at least 2)`: 10,000-20,000 mAh each (e.g. Anker), kept charged.
- [ ] **Radio** `1 per household`: a hand-crank or battery AM/FM/NOAA weather radio, such as the Midland ER310 or Eton FRX3 (~$50-70).
- [ ] **Emergency alerts**: make sure emergency alerts are turned on in your phone's settings, and sign up for your county's text alerts (Ready.gov explains how).

6. Paper

- [ ] **Phone numbers**: family, friends, doctors, your landlord, your employer, and an out-of-state contact.
- [ ] **Radio frequencies**: your area's main AM news station and an FM backup (look up your ZIP code on Radio-Locator), and which of the seven NOAA weather channels covers you (find your county on the National Weather Service's list).
- [ ] **Printed local map**: a road atlas or printouts, with the places to know marked.
- [ ] **Copies of IDs**: driver's license, passport, and birth certificate.
- [ ] **Insurance info**: health insurance cards (front and back), plus your renter's or home and car policy numbers and claims phone numbers.
- [ ] **Account numbers**: bank, credit cards, and utilities, with their phone numbers, so you can sort things out when systems come back.
- [ ] **Medication list**: your medications, doses, allergies, and doctors' numbers.

Tier 2

7. Extend food past two weeks

- [ ] **White rice** (8 lb per person): about 1,650 calories per pound, the cheapest calories that store for years.
- [ ] **Dried beans or lentils** (5 lb per person): about 1,550 calories per pound, plus the protein and fiber rice lacks.
- [ ] **Oats** (3 lb per person): about 1,700 calories per pound of breakfast.
- [ ] **Peanut butter** (2 jars per person): 16 oz jars, about 2,700 calories each.
- [ ] **Cooking oil** (1 quart per person): about 7,700 calories per quart.
- [ ] **Salt** (1 canister per household): a 26 oz canister makes rice and beans edible and replaces what you sweat out.
- [ ] **Sugar** (1 bag (4 lb) per household): quick calories that keep forever.
- [ ] **Canned vegetables** (6 cans per person): for vitamins and variety.
- [ ] **Canned meat or fish** (6 cans per person): tuna, chicken, salmon, or Spam.
- [ ] **Multivitamin** (16 tablets per person): one a day covers what a rice-and-beans diet lacks, such as vitamin C.

8. Internet: Starlink Mini

- [ ] **Hardware** (1 per household): ~$199, varies by promotion.
- [ ] **Standby mode**: ~$5-10/month depending on the source, at roughly 0.5 Mbps.
- [ ] **Sky view**: it needs a clear view of the sky from a balcony or window.

9. Power, minimal (~$1,250)

- [ ] **Battery** (1 per household): a 1 kWh LiFePO4 power station, e.g. the EcoFlow DELTA 3 Plus.
- [ ] **Solar panel** (1 per household): one 400 W folding panel, which refills ~1 kWh on a sunny day.

10. Cooking without power

- [ ] **Stove** (1 per household): a single-burner butane stove (e.g. Gas One or Iwatani, ~$25-90) or a camping canister stove.
- [ ] **Fuel** (22 canisters per household): 8 oz butane canisters.

11. Sanitation

- [ ] **Heavy trash bags** (1 box of 20 per person): contractor bags, 3 mil or thicker, in boxes of 20.
- [ ] **5-gallon bucket** (1 per household): with a snap-on toilet seat lid, like the Reliance Luggable Loo (~$20-30).
- [ ] **Kitty litter or sawdust** (1 bag per person): 20-40 lb bags.
- [ ] **Toilet paper** (9 rolls per person): more than you think.
- [ ] **Soap** (1 bar per person): bar or liquid.
- [ ] **Wipes** (3 packs of 80 per person): unscented baby wipes, for washing yourself when you can't shower.
- [ ] **Hand sanitizer** (1 bottle per person): at least 60% alcohol, for when there's no water to wash with.

12. Warmth and safety

- [ ] **Sleeping bag or heavy blankets** (1 per person): a sleeping bag rated to 20-30°F for each person, or wool blankets.
- [ ] **Fire extinguisher** (1 per household): an ABC-rated one, 5 lb or larger (e.g. First Alert or Kidde).
- [ ] **CO detector** (1 per household): battery-powered, or plug-in with a battery backup, since a plug-in alone dies with the power.
- [ ] **Gas tank above half**: keep it there from now on.

13. Pets and babies, if applicable

- [ ] **Pet food** (5 weeks' supply per pet): what they already eat, since a sudden switch upsets their stomachs.
- [ ] **Litter** (3 bags per cat): the kind your cat already uses.
- [ ] **Pet medications, vaccination records, and a carrier or leash** (1 per pet): shelters that take pets often require records and crates.
- [ ] **Formula** (5 weeks' supply per baby): your usual brand.
- [ ] **Diapers and wipes** (240 diapers per baby): in the current size and the next size up, since babies grow.

14. Morale

- [ ] **Paper books** (2 books per person): a few you've been meaning to read.
- [ ] **Cards and board games** (1 per household): a deck of cards, Uno, and a couple of board games.
- [ ] **For kids** (1 per kid): coloring books, crayons, puzzles, and a favorite small toy.
- [ ] **Treats** (2 bags per person): chocolate, candy, or whatever your household's comfort food is.
- [ ] **Notebooks and pens** (1 per household): for the paper log, lists, and notes to neighbors.

Tier 3

15. Offline library

- [ ] **Kiwix**: a free app for reading downloaded websites offline.

- [ ] **Offline maps**: Organic Maps or OsmAnd, with your state or region downloaded ahead of time.
- [ ] **Printed pages**: the 20 that matter: first aid, water purification (the EPA and CDC both have one-page guides), how to shut off your home's water and gas, and a few staple recipes.
- [ ] **Local LLM** (optional): a model run through Ollama on a laptop; an 8B-parameter model runs on most laptops with 16 GB of RAM.

16. Tools

- [ ] **Multitool** 1 per household: e.g. a Leatherman or Victorinox.
- [ ] **Duct tape** 1 roll per household: patches torn tarps, leaky hoses, and broken windows.
- [ ] **Work gloves** 1 pair per adult: leather, for debris and broken glass.
- [ ] **Zip ties** 1 pack per household: assorted sizes, for quick fixes.
- [ ] **Flashlight** 1 per household: a bright handheld one for searching and signaling.
- [ ] **Small toolkit** 1 per household: screwdrivers, an adjustable wrench, a hammer, and pliers.
- [ ] **Small solar panel** 1 per household: a 50-100 W folding USB panel keeps phones and power banks charged without the big power station.

17. Manual hand pump or siphon

- [ ] **Jiggle siphon** 1 per household (~$10-15): moves water from the tub into jugs, or fuel between cans, without sucking on a hose.

18. Power, better (~$5,000)

- [ ] **Battery** 1 per household: a 4 kWh LiFePO4 power station, e.g. the EcoFlow DELTA Pro 3.
- [ ] **Solar** 3 panels per household: 400 W folding panels, which together refill ~3 kWh/day in sun.
- [ ] **Generator** 1 per household: a ~2,500 W dual-fuel inverter generator, which refills the battery in a few hours even in bad weather.
- [ ] **Propane** 3 tanks per household: 20 lb tanks.

19. Ammunition

- [ ] **Ammunition**: a few boxes for each firearm you own, stored cool and dry.
- [ ] **Secure storage**: a lockbox or gun safe, so no one else can get to it.

Full Medicine List

Prescriptions

- [ ] **90-day supply of every daily medication**: ask your doctor to write 90-day prescriptions; many insurers cover them, especially by mail order.
- [ ] **Backup inhaler**, if you use one: keep one at home and one in your bag.
- [ ] **Epinephrine auto-injectors**, if prescribed: EpiPen or a generic.
- [ ] **Insulin and glucose strips**, if you use them: plus lancets, pen needles, and glucose tablets for lows.

Pain and fever

- [ ] **Acetaminophen** 1 bottle per household (Tylenol): fever and pain.
- [ ] **Ibuprofen or naproxen** 1 bottle per household (Advil, Aleve): pain, fever, and swelling.
- [ ] **Low-dose aspirin** 1 bottle per household (81 mg): mostly for a suspected heart attack, when chewing four tablets (325 mg) on the way to an ER can help, unless you're allergic or your doctor has told you not to.

Allergy

- [ ] **Diphenhydramine** 1 box per household (Benadryl): fast relief for hives and allergic reactions.
- [ ] **Cetirizine or loratadine** 1 box per household (Zyrtec, Claritin): non-drowsy, once a day, for ongoing allergies.
- [ ] **Hydrocortisone cream** 1 tube per household (1%): rashes, bug bites, poison ivy, and itching.

Stomach and gut

- [ ] **Loperamide** 1 box per household (Imodium): slows diarrhea so you lose less fluid.
- [ ] **Oral rehydration salts** 4 packets per person (e.g. DripDrop or WHO-formula ORS packets): replace the salt and water that diarrhea drains, and the most important item in this group.
- [ ] **Electrolyte packets** 7 packets per person (e.g. Liquid I.V. or LMNT): for heat, sweat, and hard work.
- [ ] **Bismuth subsalicylate** 1 bottle per household (Pepto-Bismol): upset stomach, nausea, and mild diarrhea.
- [ ] **Calcium carbonate antacid** 1 bottle per household (Tums): quick heartburn relief.
- [ ] **Famotidine** 1 box per household (Pepcid): longer-lasting heartburn relief, up to 12 hours.
- [ ] **Polyethylene glycol** 1 bottle per household (MiraLAX): constipation, which is common when your diet switches to rice and canned food.
- [ ] **Meclizine** 1 box per household (Bonine, Dramamine Less Drowsy): nausea from motion sickness or vertigo.

Cold and respiratory

- [ ] **Saline nasal spray** 1 bottle per household (e.g. Simply Saline): congestion, and the dry air that comes with running heaters.
- [ ] **Guaifenesin** 1 box per household (Mucinex): loosens chest mucus so coughs clear it.
- [ ] **Pseudoephedrine** 1 box per household (Sudafed, the kind behind the pharmacy counter; bring ID): the decongestant that works.
- [ ] **Cough drops** 1 bag per household (e.g. Halls or Ricola): sore throat and cough.

Wounds and skin

- [ ] **Antibiotic ointment** 1 tube per household (Polysporin or Neosporin): keeps minor wounds moist and clean.
- [ ] **Sterile gauze** 1 box per household: 4x4 pads and a roll or two, for covering wounds and pressing on bleeding.
- [ ] **Adhesive bandages** 1 box per household: assorted sizes.

- [ ] **Medical tape** (1 roll per household): paper or cloth, to hold gauze in place.
- [ ] **Elastic wrap** (1 per household) (ACE bandage): sprains, and holding dressings on.
- [ ] **Saline or clean water** (1 per household), with an irrigation syringe or squeeze bottle: enough pressure to flush dirt out of a wound.
- [ ] **Povidone-iodine** (1 bottle per household) (Betadine): kills germs on the skin around a wound.
- [ ] **Burn gel** (1 per household) (e.g. Water-Jel): for minor burns, after 20 minutes under cool running water.
- [ ] **Tweezers** (1 per household): fine-point, for splinters, glass, and ticks.
- [ ] **Trauma shears** (1 per household): cut clothing away from an injury without cutting the person.
- [ ] **Tourniquet** (1 per household): a CAT or SOF-T, bought from a reputable seller since counterfeits are common.

Eyes and mouth

- [ ] **Lubricating eye drops** (1 bottle per household) (e.g. Systane or Refresh): dry eyes from heat, smoke, or wearing contacts too long.
- [ ] **Eyewash** (1 bottle per household): sterile saline, for flushing out dust or chemicals.
- [ ] **Contact solution**: a full bottle and a spare case.
- [ ] **Temporary dental filling kit** (1 per household) (e.g. Dentemp) **and clove oil**: the kit covers a lost filling or cap, and clove oil numbs tooth pain.

Monitoring

- [ ] **Digital thermometer** (1 per household): tells a mild illness from a fever that needs care.
- [ ] **Pulse oximeter** (1 per household) (fingertip, ~$20-30): measures blood oxygen.
- [ ] **Blood pressure cuff** (1 per household): an automatic upper-arm cuff (e.g. Omron); wrist cuffs are less accurate.
- [ ] **Glucose meter**, if diabetic: plus spare strips and lancets.

Hygiene and protection

- [ ] **Nitrile gloves** (1 box of 100 per household): they protect you and the wound during first aid, and your hands when emptying the toilet bucket.
- [ ] **N95 masks** (5 masks per person): NIOSH-approved, for smoke, dust, mold cleanup, and illness.
- [ ] **Insect repellent** (1 bottle per household): 20-30% DEET or picaridin, for mosquitoes and ticks.
- [ ] **Sunscreen** (1 bottle per household): SPF 30 or higher.
- [ ] **Menstrual products**: tampons, pads, or a menstrual cup, plus Midol or ibuprofen for cramps.

Places to Know Nearby

- [ ] **Hospital emergency room** (find nearest): if phones are down, you can't call 911, so the ER is where you go instead.

- [ ] **Fire and police stations** (find nearest fire or police): they're staffed around the clock and talk over their own radio systems, which don't depend on the internet or cell towers.

- [ ] **Pharmacy** (find nearest): prescriptions are the one thing you can't improvise.

- [ ] **Grocery stores** (find nearest): know two or three, including one within walking distance.

- [ ] **Gas stations** (find nearest): pumps need power and card readers need a network.

- [ ] **Bank or credit union branch** (find nearest): ATMs and cards will likely be down, and a branch might still hand out cash against your ID if it opens at all.

- [ ] **Shelters, warming centers, and cooling centers**: usually schools, libraries, community centers, and churches your county designates ahead of time.

- [ ] **Hardware store** (find nearest): batteries, propane, tarps, water containers, and generators sell out first.

- [ ] **Nearest fresh water** (find nearest): a creek, lake, or pond is what your filter is for if the taps stop.

- [ ] **Your family's meeting place**: see For Your Family.

Upkeep

- [ ] **Water**: refill containers you filled from the tap, and replace store-bought bottles past their date.
- [ ] **Food**: eat and replace anything near its date, oldest first.
- [ ] **Batteries and power banks**: test the headlamps, flashlight, and radio, and recharge the power banks and power station.
- [ ] **Medicine**: replace anything expired, especially epinephrine, insulin, and liquids.
- [ ] **Paper**: update phone numbers, your medication list, and the places on your map.

- [ ] **Safety gear**: test the CO detector, and check that the fire extinguisher's gauge is in the green.
- [ ] **Starlink**, if you have it: power it on and make sure Standby mode still connects.
- [ ] **Family plan**: make sure everyone still knows the out-of-state contact and the meeting place.
- [ ] **Bleach**: replace it once a year, since it loses strength.

For Your Family

- [ ] **A shared plan**: one out-of-state contact everyone calls or texts, and a physical meeting place if phones are down.
- [ ] **A shared checklist**: a spreadsheet or printed page showing who has what, so you're not all buying the same things.